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Image superimposition in signed language discourse and in motion pictures – an intermedial comparison

Anke Müller
Institute of German Sign Language and Communication of the Deaf,
University of Hamburg,
Germany

Abstract
Both film and signed languages are media that make use of iconicity and employ motion images for communicative and narrative purposes. This paper focuses on simultaneously presented images that occur in film for example as double exposures and in signed languages as simultaneous constructions. While film and signed languages differ in many ways with respect to iconicity, they can be compared with respect to the way simultaneously presented motion images relate to each other. Superimpositions are defined as a simultaneous view on two or more scenes or as giving two different simultaneous representations of one scene. They serve as a means of dense information packaging. While superimpositions strongly differ in their appearance in film and signed discourse, they exhibit some similarities of structure and functions. They exploit the iconicity of spatial relations emerging in the graphic spatial dimension. Their function is to express a spatial, intentional or temporal connection between two scenes or aspects of one scene, for example the intentional relation between a cognitive activity as seen in the face of a person and the object or content of that cognitive activity.

1. Introduction

Film is a medium that mainly draws on (photo-)realistic pictures that can be understood through the same cognitive abilities as the perception of real-world scenarios affords.[1] This is due to the iconicity and mimetic aspects of the pictures, which are "isomorphic with corresponding real-world displays" (Prince 1993: 25), and which include the isomorphic representation of continuous movement say of a person acting in a certain way. With regard to this temporal quality which sets apart film images from other kinds of images that are static, film can be said to be made up of motion images. A 'motion image' has a duration, it progresses in time and also shows the progress of time through the continuous depiction of a part of a scene or action.[2] A motion image corresponds to the smallest unit of a film, the 'shot'. Thompson and Bowen (2009: 192) define the shot as "One action or event that is recorded by one camera at one time."[3] A situation is typically shown by a series of shots – or motion images – from different angles and distances, which means to break up the situation

[1] See Currie (1995) and Prince (1993) for early approaches of cognitive film studies objecting to the then dominant semiotic approaches in the wake of the linguistic turn.
[2] Cf. Currie (1995, chapters 3.4 and 3.5). He points out that "cinema is a temporal art" that differs from other types of (temporal) arts: "What is distinctively temporal about film is not its portrayal of time, but the manner of its portrayal: its portrayal of time by means of time." In other words, "temporal properties of elements of the representation serve to represent temporal properties of the things represented." (all quotations from page 96).
[3] This definition should not be understood too literally (since many segments in film are not produced with a camera anyway), but should give an idea of the basic unit. Slightly rephrased, it can extend to shots composed in technically different ways: "One action or event that could have been recorded by one camera at one time." Considering very long and complex shots that combine different locations and camera movements such as tilts, pans and tracking shots, it would be appropriate to find a definition that segments a complex shot into distinct visual gestalts or single views that serve as basic units. For the purpose of this paper, the simple definition suffices.

into many "actions" and "events". Films are edited from a variety of shots artfully composed into a narration. In this paper, I use the term 'filmed motion image' to refer to a shot. While the term shot is reserved for film descriptions, the term motion image is defined intensionally above and serves to comprise other kinds of motion images as well – images that have duration and continually show movement of an entity or the development of a situation, and that are in this respect iconic.

Signed languages also exhibit features of iconicity.[4] For example, properties of a referent can systematically be mapped onto corresponding features of a sign, such that the shape, orientation or movement characteristics of an entity (animate or not) are perceivable in the handshape, orientation or movement of the hand. The assumed similarity in the respective aspects is the iconic ground[5] by which further analogies and specifications can be understood, for example location and movement path within the signing space. This kind of iconic relation is exploited in signed constructions in which the hands represent entities, parts of entities or body parts as figures and background. Upper body, head and facial expression also at times feature as articulators. These constructions are not only used to refer to an entity or situation, but in particular to show and demonstrate what this entity does, how it behaves or looks like, and how and where it moves. It is this quality of representing the movement of a referent by a corresponding movement of an articulator representing that referent that leads to equally regard these iconic signing constructions as – in this case signed – motion images. In this paper I will use the term 'signed motion image' to refer to iconic signing constructions as indicated above.[6] A signed motion image is determined by the whole gestalt movement of one or more body articulators, like in a manual sign or a gesture, a body posture or a facial expression. Mostly it is the stroke or a decisive, prolonged hold or an accentuated bodily movement that is the genuine depictive element.[7] Transitional movements are not considered a part of the iconic representation of a referent.

Despite all dissimilarities, film and signed languages as communicative systems have two essential features in common. Films are made of and signed languages employ motion images that have a duration and while progressing in time also show the progress of time through the continuous depiction of a part of a scene or action. Second, both systems relate motion images to other motion images for meaning construction. As for film, motion images following one after another are the basic device for storytelling. Sequential relations of motion images are well known as the core concept of editing or montage. In signed discourse, motion images also relate to one another sequentially, also across inserted lexical signs that have not the quality of a motion image.

Apart from being sequentially ordered, motion images in signing and in film can also occur simultaneously and establish simultaneous relations, which is the case in image superimpositions.[8] The idea of presenting two motion images at the same time is equally well at the heart of cinema as are sequences[9], though we might not be aware of it. On the contrary, image superimpositions in cinema as can be seen in double exposures are comparatively marked or conspicuous, since they reveal and expose the technique of film-making and as

[4] See Mandel (1977) for an early account of iconicity in signed languages. Meanwhile literature on iconicity in signed languages abounds, see e.g. Taub (2001) and, for a general account on iconicity in spoken and signed languages, Perniss at al. (2010); see e.g. Aronoff et al. (2005) on the iconic foundation of simultaneous features across sign languages and Cuxac and Sallandre (2007) on the iconicity of the kind of signed constructions this paper focuses on.

[5] See the summary of basic Peircean terms in Sonesson (this volume, chapter 3).

[6] A detailed description of different types and forms is given in chapter 2.

[7] See Kita et al. (1998) for the adaptation and further development of a segmental description of gestures in terms of phases of preparation, stroke, hold and retraction to signs, that is units of signed languages.

[8] Image superimposition is a general term which will be defined and specified in chapter 3.

[9] See Edgar Morins (2005) essay on "The Cinema, or The Imaginary Man".

such are prone to meaning enrichment. In signed language discourse however, image superimpositions are quite unobtrusive and frequently found.

It is the simultaneous use of motion images this paper is focused on. In comparing forms and uses of image superimposition in two distinct semiotic systems such as film and signed languages, this paper seeks to gain insight into how meaning construction with motion images is done. It addresses the question of whether there is an iconic ground not to the images themselves (which can be taken as granted), but to the simultaneous presentation of two motion images, and which kinds of iconic relations can be found. These may not be the same as for sequences. An iconic relation of sequences of motion images is for example the temporal sequence of events mirrored by the temporal sequence of distinct motion images.

2. Motion images in signed language discourse – highly iconic structures

While a film is obviously composed of sequences of motion images interrelated globally and locally in manifold ways, the case is not this straightforward with signed languages. This chapter deals with the iconic features of signed languages used for demonstrating and showing and explains the common ground on which signed motion images and filmed motion images can be compared. It provides detailed examples and illustrations to give readers not familiar with sign languages an idea of what signed motion images look like and how they are integrated into discourse, and at the same time explains how and to what extent these signed constructions may be described as motion images similar to filmed motion images.

In sign languages, there are two main types of manual signs: The established lexicon of conventional signs, which may or may not be iconically motivated, and productive signs making use of iconic relations between sign form and extralinguistic reality, which enable signers literally to show motion images while and in signing. Productive signs are not restricted to the hands but also include the use of the whole (mostly upper) body and face (Sallandre and Cuxac 2002: 174). Cuxac and Sallandre (2007:15), who call these "highly iconic structures" (a term I will adopt here), emphasize that they "arise from the deliberate intent to show, illustrate and demonstrate while telling", and they are widely attested in sign languages of the world studied so far.[10] There are two main types of highly iconic structures, which, as far back as Mandel (1977: 78), have been called "modeling" and "staging". In modeling, only the hands are used and entities are represented in model scale (see Figures 1.2 and 1.3 below), which can vary according to needs (cf. Schick 1990: 32). Staging however implies the use of the body in order to enact a person or an animate being and show their actions, behavior and feelings, most often applying life-size scale because it is human beings that are represented (see Figure 1.1).

In sign language linguistics, there is different terminology regarding the phenomena in question, involving different conceptualizations. While staging is referred to with role-taking in general, divided into action role shift and quotation role shift (Herrmann and Pendzich 2018) or constructed action along with constructed dialogue,[11] modeling was also analyzed as use of classifier predicates (Supalla 1986), as polymorphemic verbs (Engberg-Pedersen 1993)

[10] There are at least two slots in Quer et al. (2017) SignGram, a blueprint and check list for writing grammars of signed languages, devoted to the constructions I refer to: "Part 4 Morphology Chapter 5 Classifiers" and "Part 7 Pragmatics Chapter 6 Reporting and role shift". Schembri (2003: 3) lists some sign languages with classifiers. SIGNGRAM builds on at least 42 different sign languages.

[11] Role-taking is an early emerged term still used especially for an intertheoretical understanding. Constructed action was coined by Metzger (1995) in analogy to Tannen's (1989) concept of (animated) constructed dialogue and is widely used within cognitive linguistics approaches. The differentiation of communicative actions including propositional acts vs. other kinds of actions is common, as the display of the former has different characteristics and affords additional means of description. See Lillo-Martin (2012) for a historical outline of approaches and terminology.

or depicting verbs (Liddell 2003), to name a few.[12] Sallandre and Cuxac (2002: 175) use the term transfer (of person, situation, and size and form) to highlight the iconic value of said constructions and state: “These transfers are the visible traces of cognitive operations, which consist in transferring the real world into the four-dimensionality (the three dimensions of space plus the dimension of time) of signed discourse“. For the purpose of this article, I will use the terms constructed action (CA) or constructed dialogue (CD) and depicting constructions (DC) to refer to staging and modeling respectively, and I adopt Cuxac’s and Sallandre’s term “highly iconic structures” to refer to the terms as a whole.

In utterances, highly iconic structures are predominantly used as predicates and often the syntactic structure is a lexeme denoting a referential entity followed by one or more predicative items including CA and DC (cf. Fischer and Müller 2014:115). Utterances containing such predicates follow the grammar, but highly iconic structures can also be regarded from a different perspective in their pictorial sense. Different from non-depictive predicates, they exhibit the pictorial property of presenting an entity at the same time as their qualities or behavior. Denotation and predication are, in other words, inseparable. The action of walking cannot be shown without also showing the entity (animal or person) doing the walking, and this is true for both life-sized and model-sized scale. Sallandre and Cuxac (2002:175) point out that, in a CA, “the signer ‘disappears’ and ‘becomes’ a protagonist in the narrative”, and for DC, Mandel (1977: 65) explicitly states: “the signer’s articulator actually becomes the picture”, e.g. “an airplane flying”.[13] We can regard highly iconic structures as motion images showing figure, ground, movement, spatial and temporal relation, and as such, these can be compared to motion images that make up film.

The following examples from German Sign Language (DGS) are taken from a process description found in the DGS corpus MY DGS – annotated, release 3.[14] The annotated signed utterances can be viewed online. In this task informants were asked to describe in detail a process they know well, for example how to change a tire. The signer of this example chooses to dramatize his description and tell a story about his driving (Figure 1.1) along the autobahn, the German kind of expressway with at least two lanes for each direction, when one tire of his car explodes. He tells and shows how he carefully drives to the side, gets out of the car observing the ongoing traffic, gets the breakdown triangle and walks along the side lane (Figure 1.2) to put it down, goes around the car (Figure 1.3) to get out tools and spare tire, then finally how he gets the broken tire off (Figure 2.1 – 2.5) and the spare tire on. This narrative description takes about 3 minutes (02:54 min). The transcript is segmented into 48 utterance sections that are translated into German or English. The signs are represented by glosses in capital letters as annotated in the DGS corpus. Tokens of $PROD* refer to a productive use (DC), the occurrence of CA is added by the author. The signer uses many DCs, but also other kinds of relevant iconic constructions like modified lexemes as explained below. He starts with a lexeme meaning “driving a car”, which is iconically motivated by hands holding a steering-wheel (manipulative technique[15], see Figure 1.1). Here, the iconicity of the lexeme is reactivated and elaborated by a full enactment or CA as is visible in the facial

[12] There is a long debate concerning classifier constructions or depicting verbs which is summarized and discussed in Schembri (2003). Since the work of Liddell (2003) and subsequently Dudis (2004, 2011) the use of “depiction” has been widely adopted, which proves a turning point in the history of sign language linguistics as it acknowledges the depictive quality of a certain sign type.

[13] Mandel (1977:65) calls this a “substitutive depiction” as opposed to “virtual depiction”, which would be the tracing of an object’s outline into the air.

[14] My DGS – annotated: https://doi.org/10.25592/dgs.corpus-3.0; the process description can be accessed here: https://www.sign-lang.uni-hamburg.de/meinedgs/html/1584329-15450503-15475829_en.html.

[15] See the description of “image-producing techniques” in Konrad et al. (this volume), including the “manipulative technique” with hands depicted as hands, the “substitutive technique” with hands representing entities, and the “sketching technique” where forms of referents are traced into the air.

expression and movement of the upper body. It can be regarded as an iconic modification, hence a signed motion image.[16]

Three signs make up the first utterance section of the process description: two occurrences of iconic modifications of the lexeme CAR-DRIVING2* framing a lexeme denoting 'autobahn', which specifies where the driving takes place. In the two motion images (with the duration of 0.940 sec and 1.010 sec) the driver and his general mood are visible – the steering-wheel, the front of the car or the surroundings are not, although conceptually present. This parsimony of pictorial information is an essential and common feature of signed motion images, which accounts for its conciseness. Still, in recalling a typical breakdown situation, the signer shows, illustrates and demonstrates a lot and in great detail. In the course of events, he depicts the situation from different angles and distances. For example, a person can be represented at close range (as the driver in Figure 1.1), but also at a greater distance, as in Figure 1.2, and even further away, as in Figure 1.3. Each sign has a duration and shows a human in motion. In Figure 1.2 the two forefingers of the hands are used to depict each a leg or part of a leg, whereas in Figure 1.3 the two fingers of one hand refer to the two legs of a person. The first DC with its two fingers more apart implies a larger stride than the compact one-handed DC and accordingly represents the person from a closer point of view.

1.1 – section 1 /sign 1	1.2 – section 12 /sign 4	1.3 – section 17 /sign 1
CAR-DRIVING2*	$PROD*	TO-GO2A* (right hand)
CA: person driving	DC: person walking forwards	DC: person walking around
00:00.20	00:43.30	01:00.23

Figure 1. Three ways to show a human in action[17]

The size variability in the range of person representations is not accidental but serves communicative purposes, as different aspects can be profiled. While it is the counting of steps to achieve a distance of 200 meters that is alluded to and highlighted in section 12, in section 17 the movement to the back of the car just serves to switch the focus to a new location, which is done by a short movement in a more distanced view.

These examples of signed motion images taken from different sections but always representing the same character (Figure 1) evoke the different shot sizes known from filmed motion images and this is a similarity between film and signed discourse often noticed.[18] Shot size, which will be described in more detail below, is a significant but not the only feature that

[16] For details on iconic modification see Konrad et al. (this volume). The annotation of a * following the gloss indicates a modification of the base form of the lexeme, albeit not always an iconic modification.
[17] See https://www.sign-lang.uni-hamburg.de/meinedgs/html/1584329-15450503-15475829_en.html - t00000020 for Figure 1.1, https://www.sign-lang.uni-hamburg.de/meinedgs/html/1584329-15450503-15475829_en.html#t00004330 for Figure 1.2, and for Figure 1.3 https://www.sign-lang.uni-hamburg.de/meinedgs/html/1584329-15450503-15475829_en.html#t00010023.
[18] See Müller (2018: 57-74).

accounts for such a similarity. Figure 2 presents a short sequence to give an impression of the flow and composition of different motion images. In section 32, the signer shows how the driver loosens the screws of the tire and begins to take it off (Figure 2.1). This is shown in a CA, which can be analyzed as an iconic modification of the lexeme predicate TO-TAKE-OFF-OBJECT1 with manipulative technique. This action is only accomplished with the first sign of section 34, as can be seen in Figure 2.5. Section 33 presents some circumstances of the action. The motion image of Figure 2.1 is followed by a very short instance of a deictic lexeme – with his thumb, the signer points backwards[19] – and then his right hand depicts in another motion image what is going on there: two cars speed along. The flat hand is conventional for depicting the movement of cars and other vehicles (substitutive technique), the finger tips mapping the front side, and each stroke of the repeated movement represents a car as seen from a little distance (from the road side – the broken tire is obviously at the left side of the car and the driver is dangerously exposed to the rushing traffic). In the next moment, the driver is in focus again, sweat dripping from his temple (Figure 2.4). This sign is a modified lexeme – in its base form, two hands visualize drops of sweat going down the face – and not a productive sign as such, but its depictive value – finger tips as sweat drops – is fitted into the narrated scene, even more so as the signer still enacts the protagonist being aware of his precarious situation in subsequent CAs[20], and then the action of taking off the tire is completed (Figure 2.5). Note that during section 33 the left hand is still in the same place as in Figure 2.1 to keep the situation backgrounded.[21] Thus, three different motion images are neatly put together: the driver at the tire from up close — distant view on traffic situation in his back — driver at close range again first with focus on sweat pearls and then on his working at the tire.

Section 32: “[I now remove the screws so] I can take off the tire.”

2.1– section 32 /last	2.2 – section 33 /0	2.3 – section 33 /1	
TO-TAKE-OFF-OBJECT1*	[IN-THE-BACK-OF5]	$PROD* (right hand), repeated movement	
CA: handling the tire	lexeme/deixis	DC: cars from side; CA: being aware of traffic	
01:48.19		01:49.37	end of sign

Section 33: “The cars are still speeding past and make me break a sweat.”

[19] In the transcript, the sign IN-THE-BACK-OF5 is not annotated and has been added by the author.

[20] The agitated movement of the signer looking left and right as if being aware of the rushing traffic can be attributed to the character of the story, so that there is a CA in parallel to the DC; the same with Figure 2.4 where a CA is paralleled to a lexeme. These are simultaneous constructions and Figure 2.3 is in fact an image superimposition of the kind described in chapter 4.

[21] Liddell (2003) coined the term buoy for parts of signs being persevered. In this case it is a depicting buoy and is a text cohesive device as it connects two parts of a proposition while another one is inserted.

2.4 – section 33 /2	2.5 – section 34 /1
TO-SWEAT1C*	TO-TAKE-OFF-OBJECT1*
CA: emotion	CA: handling the tire
01:50.29	01:51.20
Section 34: “I remove the broken tire […]”	

Figure 2. Sequence showing the scene of taking off a tire while cars race past[22]

This composition of signed motion images reminds of the editing in film, where different viewpoints are combined. It is not only the change of distances that can be observed in signed motion images, but also the use of different angles of view, as to imply changing standpoints. In Figure 2 for example, the perspective onto the scene has shifted about 90 degree as compared to the beginning in Figure 1.1 which presented the driver sitting in his car from somewhere in front of the car. Now the protagonist is still presented frontally although he is situated on the left side of his car as the movement direction of the ongoing traffic proves.

As in film, there are many ways to imply invisible or off elements in signed discourse, for example through the direction of the gaze which serves to indicate the – invisible – presence of another character or object that is being looked at (see e.g. Branigan 1984 for film; Müller 2013 and Fischer and Müller 2014 for signed languages). And while both in film and in signed motion images there are characters and objects off-screen or off the signing space – known to be there but for the moment invisible, there are more kinds of invisible but conceptually present objects in signed discourse. This holds for all objects handled or manipulated (the steering-wheel in Figure 1.1, the tire in Figure 2), but also for parts of entities, such as a person only visible by their legs as in the DCs in Figures 1.2 and 1.3, and entities that are traced into the air and so made visible transiently (see Figure 4.1 below). Context information and pattern completion (see Dudis 2004: 228) account for a more ample knowledge of what is shown than what is literally visible from one moment to another.

It should have become evident that CA and DC have the properties of motion images in their own right. This also applies to lexemes whose underlying iconic value is exploited by modifying them according to the scenes elaborated in the discourse. As images, they can be described as any image, taking reference, gestalt, viewing angle and distance as well as movement (relative to a viewpoint) into account. Basic shot description in film practice and theory supplies us with terminology apt not only to describe single motion images (in the sense defined above), but also sequences and patterns. Although there is no real camera in signed discourse, the point of view and possibly motion of a virtual camera can be inferred from the spatial and perspectival characteristics of the image shown[23]. The addressee of

[22] See https://www.sign-lang.uni-hamburg.de/meinedgs/html/1584329-15450503-15475829_en.html#t00014819 for the start of the sequence.

[23] For details see Müller (2018: 133-147). Figure 1.1 is an example of a signed motion image analogue to a tracking shot. Since the car driver is supposed to be moving forward but is portrayed statically, this implies a moving virtual camera.

signed discourse thus corresponds to the film viewer, and accordingly takes on the perspective of the virtual camera.

Several scholars of sign language studies have mentioned similarities between the use of highly iconic structures and film (for an overview, see Müller 2018: 49-94) especially with respect to shot sizes. Constructed action, articulated by head, face, upper body, arms and hands corresponds to a medium close-up shot, while depicting constructions can range from "distant shot" to "extreme close-up shot" (Bauman 2003: 38), depending on what scale is applied. As the concept of shot sizes will be needed in the subsequent chapters, some more details on the transfer are due. The rationale of allocating shot sizes to highly iconic structures roughly refers to the apparent size of the visible depictive element (see Müller 2018: 178-186 for a detailed argumentation). I adopt a scale common in film studies which uses three sizes of close, medium and long distance, which each have three subdivisions (cf. Thompson and Bowen 2009: 14-21). In film, a very long shot or distant shot presents an overview of a situation, where persons are seen within their surroundings. A long shot shows a person in their entirety, whereas a medium long shot shows them from around the knees on upwards. From a medium close-up on – which is the portrait size of a person showing the upper body and face – facial expression is clearly visible and interpretable. There are functional equivalences between film and sign shot sizes, e.g. the relevance of facial expressions in CA respectively (medium) close-up shots, but not one-to-one (Müller 2018: 208-210). In the example above, different shot sizes are exemplified in signed constructions all representing the same person: a CA as a medium close-up in Figure 1.1, a DC as a medium long shot in Figure 1.2 and an iconic modification of a lexeme as a long shot in Figure 1.3. The handshape of an upright index finger can be used to depict an upright person which resembles the very long or distant shot. Here, the finger maps onto an upright person from top to toe and not legs only. The depiction of cars speeding past in Figure 2.3 corresponds to a long shot. This kind of depiction often occurs in combination with the two-legged DC and so can be allocated to the same shot size.[24]

There are many differences between signed discourse and film, the most striking one the photo-realistic way or the abundance of illustrative depiction in film as opposed to a comparatively focused and compact kind of depicting in signed languages.[25] However, highly iconic structures in sign language discourse can be regarded as signed motion images and, as such, as analogous to film shots. This underlying similarity allows for a description of signed motion images with the concepts of a basic shot description that we know from film studies. This is not to say that signed discourse in its entirety can be paralleled to film sequences, but only the segments of highly iconic constructions and similar uses. Nevertheless, there is spatial coherence between the single signed motion images, whether they be contiguous or not.[26]

3. Superimposition as a simultaneous combination of two or more motion images

Chapter 3 introduces the notion of superimposition with a discussion of a general definition, as well as key concepts necessary for the description and analysis of form and function. For ease of reception, I will only refer to two distinct motion images superimposed, but the same device is applicable to three and more.

An image superimposition in a film can be easily identified when semi-transparency is involved, resulting in a possibly disturbing interference and ambivalence of two layers. But images may also be composed by way of locating figures and background in a way that

[24] See table 3 in Müller (2018: 211) for shot sizes of person representations in DGS as compared to film.
[25] Cf. McCleary and Viotti (2010: 185).
[26] Note that location in sign space is a reference tracking device in sign languages.

salient figures from both input images are clearly perceivable. This is the general case in signed languages, as signed motion images consist of less material and no background scenery. Image superimpositions should not be defined by their appearance alone, but by the way they are constructed. For a comparison of sign language and film, the term superimposition shall be defined A) as a simultaneous view on two or more spaces or B) as giving two different simultaneous representations of one space. An example of the first case would be a combination of one shot of a scene at one location and another shot of a different scene at another location, but also a combination of two shots where the camera is turned 180 degrees, for example a shot of a presenter of a talk superimposed on their view of the audience. An example of the second case would be a close-up of a person combined with a long shot of the same person and their immediate surrounding, or a character presented from two slightly different angles. Note that one of the input object spaces is totally or partly covered by the other.

Image superimposition does not imply that both input motion images coextend in time exactly. They can, but one may also be contained within the other, or superimpositions may result from an overlapping of two subsequent motion images. The latter is, in film, the common praxis of a dissolve, a transition from one motion image to the next, often indicating a change of place or time. While it is debatable whether a dissolve as a short transition should be considered an instance of superimposition at all, it might appear so when prolonged. There is a gradual cline from dissolves to extended dissolves (lasting two seconds and more) to congruence and temporal containment of motion images. In signed discourse we can also observe different forms of temporal alignment of two motion images; additionally, some signed motion images are built up incrementally such that one pictorial element of an image appears later than another one.[27] In this paper, the examples presented are clear cases of superimpositions and not just short temporal overlaps.

If we want to talk about image superimpositions and the parts they are made of, some crucial distinctions well known in film studies are to be made with respect to different spatial categories. An image presenting an object space always presents it from a certain point of view (where the virtual camera is located). The resulting space shown in the image can be called the 'architectural space'. Viewers of a film – or a signed narration – mentally construct from all given fragment views an object space where the narration takes place, regardless of the perspective they were shown. This space is called the 'diegetic space' and is based on visual input. Most important, there is the 'representational space' where the image is projected. It is known as 'screen space' in the context of film studies and, in sign language linguistics, as 'signing space' in front of and surrounding the signer.

In motion image superimpositions, there are two motion images of two architectural spaces projected onto the same representational space, and additional – graphic – relations between elements of the distinct architectural spaces emerge on the representational space. So could, for example, characters located in far-away places seemingly interact directly with each other. Note that a close-up view and, say, a medium shot of the same character constitute two different architectural spaces, although the object space is roughly the same.

4. Forms and functions of superimpositions in German Sign Language (DGS)

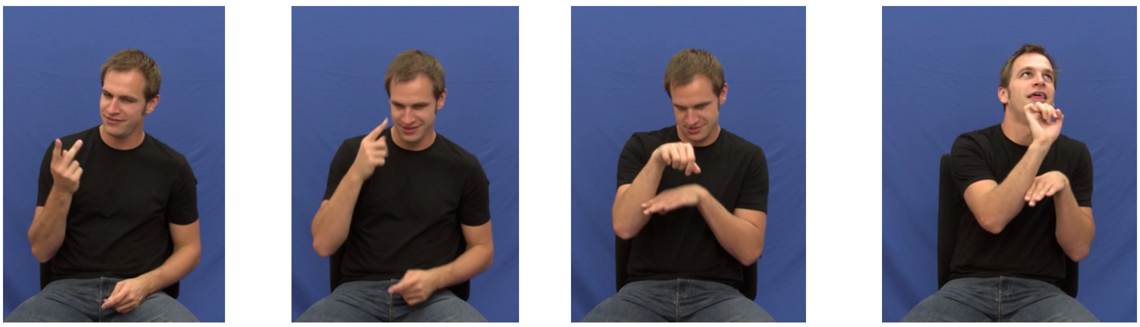
Highly iconic structures often occur in dense constructions with several information units simultaneously given (see Vermeerbergen 2007). This becomes apparent in the notion of 'body partitioning' (Dudis 2004): The signer embodies one character with their body and head, while the hands also represent entities or characters (e.g. Figure 2.3). The simultaneous

[27] See for example the description of the signed motion image for skyscrapers (Figure 4.1) or the description of Figure 5.2, both in chapter 4 of this paper.

combination of a constructed action with a depicting construction continues to be an outstanding topic in sign language linguistics. It has been observed in many sign languages and described under different labels, e.g. “double transfer” (Sallandre and Cuxac 2002: 175 for French Sign Language), “multiple perspectives” (Aarons and Morgan 2003 for South African Sign Language), “multiple real-space blends” (Dudis 2004: 225 for ASL), “parallelized CA” (Fischer and Müller 2014: 116, first in Fischer and Kollien 2006 for DGS), and “simultaneous perspective constructions” (Perniss 2007, also for DGS). At first glance, one should think that these might all be superimpositions in the sense of a simultaneous combination of motion images straight away. This is not necessarily the case, since Dudis (2004: 234) points out the possibility of combining a CA person “surrogate” with a DC in a single image – or blend, as he puts it. He gives the example of a “homeowner” and a “leaking faucet”, where the faucet is depicted at a man’s arm’s length, just where it would be positioned in a real situation. In other words, the depiction of the situation shows one architectural space and there is no image superimposition involved.

Some typical cases of body partitioning may however be described as multiple projections or ‘superimpositions’ of motion images. Two different types can be distinguished (see Müller 2018: 228). The first is a superimposition with a ‘double representation’ of an animated entity, the second is a kind of ‘complementary representation’, where two motion images interrelate that have no entities or objects in common. These will be demonstrated in the following two examples taken from a conversation about travelling experiences also found in the DGS corpus. To give a context, the first part is described and represented by the English translation.

In example 1, conversation partner B, a young man, talks about his trips to Tokyo and New York. In section 00:07:05.40 – 00:07:09.00 he says: “I’m telling you, I felt my neck getting all stiff”, adding a CA-demonstration of feeling his stiff neck. His interlocutor, A, cuts in with a DC showing a turning head with her closed hand, thus co-constructing and anticipating B’s utterance continuation. This results in a short parallel signing (during items 1 and 2 of Figure 3 below), while B continues his talk as shown in Figure 3.3 and 3.4. The time code refers to the beginning of the sign; longer durations of a CA plus DC are annotated as a time span. The utterance is ended by a palm-up gesture accompanied by a headshake (not represented in the illustration).



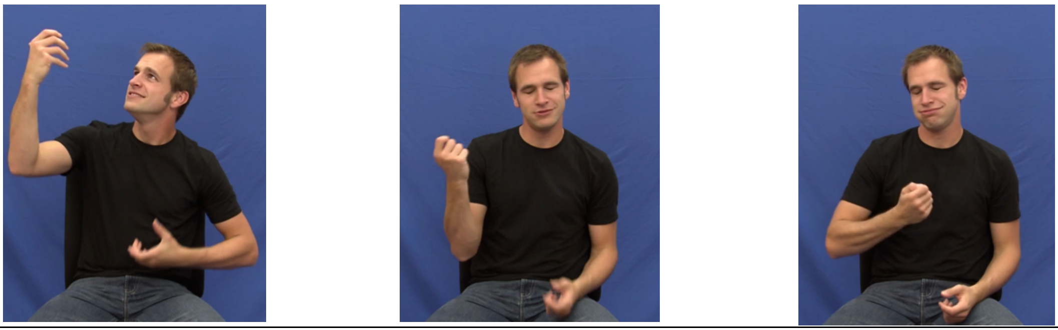
3.1	3.2	3.3	3.4
LIKE4A*	HEAD1A	$PROD* + CA	$PROD* + CA
		DC: raise head	DC: turn and move head
		CA: raise head	CA: turn and move head
07:09.20	07:09.48	07:09.76	07:10.16-07:11.70

... because I was looking up so much.

Figure 3. B’s utterance, first part[28] (sequence 00:07:05.40 – 00:07:12.17)

[28] The sequence starts at https://www.sign-lang.uni-hamburg.de/meinedgs/html/1210763_en.html#t00070627.

In this example, signer B shows how he raised his head and turned it from side to side, as expressed with items 3.3 and 3.4. There is no prosodic separation between the two consecutive actions and they can be treated as one signed motion image showing a progress of time. The CA part mimes the movement and facial expression of someone turning their head in awe, as in a medium close-up shot. At the same time, the signer shows the same actions through a DC, a second signed motion image: The right hand represents a head and the left hand represents a shoulder. It is the same action, but in a different view. The representation of the DC head plus shoulder is similar to a medium long shot. As there are two representations of the same person, but in different architectural spaces, this is a clear case of a superimposition (with double representation). In this superimposition, the DC profiles the action while the CA shows the feelings through facial expression.



4.1	4.2	4.3
HIGHRISE3* + CA	TO-EXAGGERATE1*	VERY6
re-iconized lexeme: skyscrapers		
CA: look at skyscrapers		
07:12.26 – 07:13.52	07:13.70	07:13.88
	Those skyscrapers, it's crazy!	

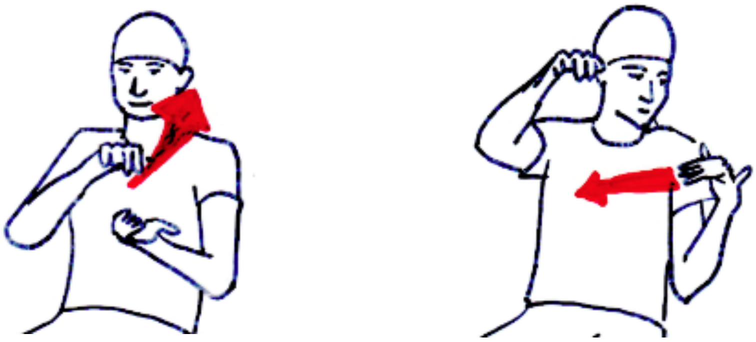
Figure 4. B's utterance, second part (sequence 00:07:12.17 – 00:07:14.21)

In example 2 (see Figure 4), which is the continuation of example 1, signer B shows why he kept his head tilted so much. The lexeme HIGHRISE3* is modified for an alternating movement. In its base form, the two hands move in parallel to trace the shape of a building from bottom to top. Through the alternating movement, each hand traces one small side of a tall building, leaving the other one invisible. As the lexeme is situated in a dramatic scene created through the context, the gaze and the head movement, it can be interpreted as a signed motion image, corresponding to a very long shot.[29] The simultaneously produced CA is a second signed motion image of a medium close-up view of the character. It is obvious that there is no double representation in item 4.1. Yet it classifies as a superimposition as two distinct architectural spaces are involved. Although the signer seems to be looking in the direction of his hand, the character of the signed motion image is looking somewhere farther away into the distance, where the tops of the buildings can be imagined by the addressee. Both images are connected by the intentional relation that exists between the character looking at something and the object he looks at. This link between the two entities is directly visible in the representational space, since the character of motion image one looks into the direction of the visible skyscrapers of motion image two. The device of superimposition offers an economic and concise way of exploiting graphic relations between elements of

[29] This iconically modified lexeme is an example of the sketching technique to depict the form of an entity. Although the depicted entity is only transiently visible, the resulting motion image can be assigned a shot size. In this kind of signed motion image, the movement of the hands does not refer to the movement of an entity.

distinct motion images to give a complex view on a situation and the way it is mirrored in the face of a protagonist.

A third example shows a combination of both types of superimposition introduced above. Complex forms like this evolve gradually within a context, adding and taking away visual information step by step.



5.1	5.2
DC-right: person walking DC-left: part of a bridge (repeated movement)	DC-right: person on bridge DC-left: water flowing in river (start 00:10.22) CA: person looking down bridge
00:08.98-00:09.90	00:09.92-00:10.48
One can walk on the bridge	and look down and watch the water.

Figure 5. Combination of double and complementary representation[30]

In a meaning-explanation of the concept bridge, the signer C first creates a scene with a river and a bridge crossing it, using DCs and re-iconized lexemes. Then C shows a typical use of a bridge: People can walk upon (Figure 5.1). This is done with a two-handed DC motion image akin to a long shot.[31] In Figure 5.2 the right hand has come to a rest, still depicting the person on the bridge, but in a defocused way. The next motion image is a CA of the same person blending in as a medium close-up. In this CA, which I refer to as motion image one, signer C shows how the person on the bridge looks down, which continues all the while (till 00:10.48). Meanwhile the left hand has finished its transitional movement to the side (not illustrated), where it turns into another DC (starting at 00:10.22) showing the water running below (indicated by the red arrow in Figure 5.2), hence motion image two, where the right-hand DC easily fits in. Now there is a completed view of the scene from a distance (long shot), and spatial relations are visible within one architectural space: The person on a (invisible) bridge and a river beneath her – a motion image with two visible elements. From the identity of the character seen in the long shot and the character simultaneously seen in the medium close-up – and as such these two elements constitute a superimposition with double representation – the person's action of looking at something becomes apparent. The object the person is looking at is shown by the left-hand DC, and so the character from motion image one (CA) and the water from motion image two (DC) can be regarded as elements of a superimposition with complementary representation. Again, it is the graphic relations showing up in the representational space that allow for the described inference.

[30] This example is taken from "Bedeutungserklärung Brücke (DGS)" [Meaning-Explanation Bridge] 2001.

[31] Note that shot size is not an absolute measure and it might be debatable whether to compare this DC to a very long shot would be more suitable. What is important here is to pinpoint the size difference between the person representations by means of DC or CA.

Forms of superimposition found in DGS consist of double representation and complementary representation, or combinations of the two.[32] The depicted entities belong to different architectural spaces. Sequential embedding is crucial to the understanding of complex superimposition (Figure 5). Superimpositions are apt to give simultaneous overview information on a situation or event with respect to spatial relations, but at the same time focus on a protagonist and their reaction to or evaluation of the situation through a visible facial expression. This is an economical and precise device for sign languages to compress space as well as be detailed and concise on mental acts, cognitive processes and human behavior.

5. Forms and functions of superimpositions in motion pictures

A prototypical superimposition in motion pictures is the double or multiple exposure, a technique dating from photography at the end of the 19th century and already used by Méliès (Tybjerg 2016: 119). It is easily recognized by the transparency of some of the visible objects or persons, with the result that one spot on the screen is covered by two objects at the same time. Ghost apparitions were the first subjects of double exposure – something made visible from some other, spiritual realm that seems to be literally laid upon the real world photographed. The spectral appearance was achieved through double exposure. Regarding our definition of a superimposition in chapter 2, the classical ghost representation only marginally fits, as there is only one architectural space integrating spectral and real entities involved in the resulting picture. Bazin wanted to dispose of the double exposure as a cinematic device, which in his eyes was outdated and not even sufficient to give a realistic impression of a spectral ghost (cf. Tybjerg's 2016 discussion on Bazin's famous 1946 paper, "The Life and Death of Superimposition"). But double exposures were and are not reserved for ghost apparitions, they were also used in documentaries and art films, for example by Vertov in the 1930ies. Today, they retain the atmosphere of early cinema and film noir and are likely to be used as a nostalgic device or a marker recalling a special film genre (Vernet according to Galt 2005: 15) – this is true for example for *The Artist* (F 2011), a silent movie which abounds of double and multiple exposures and thus evokes the mood and style of a silent movie of the time. So even if their death has been announced, a revival of double exposures especially in the digital era can be observed, as for example in *Only Lovers Left Alive* (D/GB 2013) or *Sherlock* (BBC Series 3 – UK 2014), which both apply the device for various purposes without generally seeking the allusion to former times.

In the following, I will present some typical forms and functions and illustrate my findings with some examples mostly taken from more recent films. In *Only Lovers Left Alive*, there is a sequence accompanied mainly by instrumental music from timecode 00:29:57 to 00:31:26[33], where the first protagonist, Eve, a vampire, prepares for a journey to visit her lover Adam, and packs her bags. In a sequence of single motion image shots, we see her in her room picking a book from a piled-up stack, a close-up of a book lying open on the floor with her reading hands on it from Eves perspective (motive A, see Figure 6.1 as an example), a close-up reverse shot showing Eve's face looking downwards (motive B in Figure 6.2, eyeline match to previous shot), then an extended dissolve to a medium shot showing Eve from behind as she puts books into two open suitcases (motive C, not illustrated). Motive C presents us two times with a sequence of double exposures in 00:30:22 and again from 00:30:33-37. The suitcases stay fixed, but Eve is seen repeatedly putting books in; time gaps and overlaps are at play as we see one projection of Eve fade out or stay transparent while another projection of Eve comes by and so forth. This is an example of a double exposure

[32] For further examples and discussion of signed motion image superimpositions see Müller (2018: 221-248 and 256-258).
[33] Note that due to the DVD display the timecode is only exact to the second, not to single frames.

with double representation, and the architectural space in both motion images is shared – with the exception of one element, Eve. The two simultaneous representations of Eve are not referring to the same time.[34]

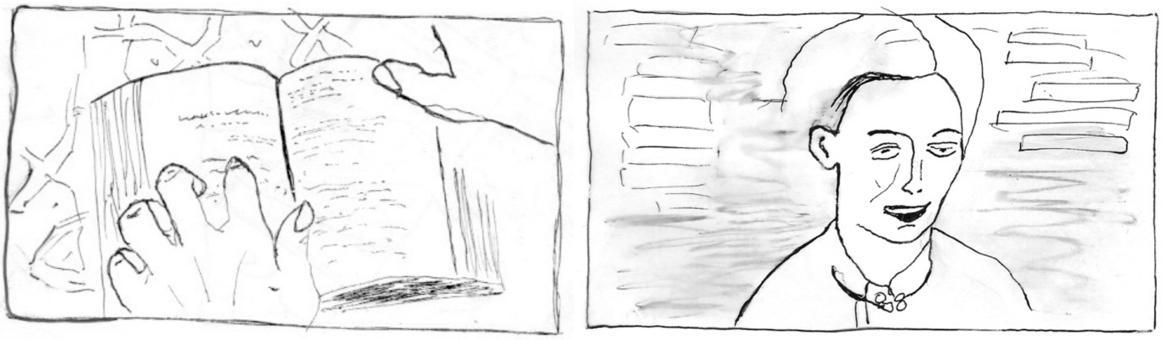


Figure 6.1 and 6.2. Motive A (00:30:07) and motive B (00:30:12) as single motion images

The second kind of double exposure has been prepared through the sequence of motives A and B and it also occurs several times in variations. Starting at timecode 00:30:28 where motive A is visible as a single image for a time, a fourth motive blends in, an extreme close-up of Eve's eyes, covering the whole screen (motive D, see Figure 7.1). Two distinct architectural spaces showing objects from opposite directions are combined on the representational space to give the impressions of eyes directly lying on the pages they are reading (Figure 7.2).[35] Motive D does not occur as a single motion image.

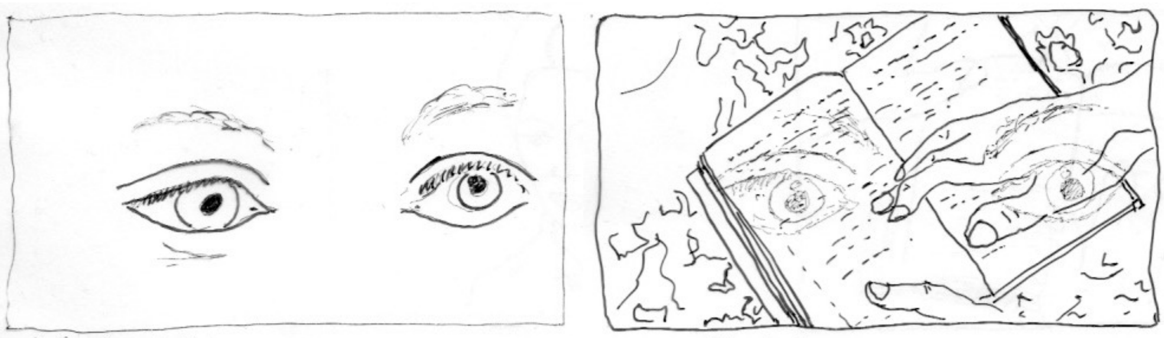


Figure 7.1 and 7.2. Motive D isolated and superimposed to motive A (00:30:47)

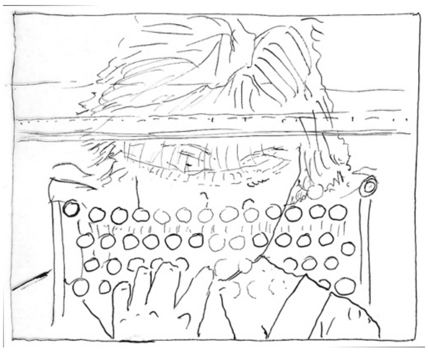
While the 'eyes' are on, the book changes. Motive D serves as an image bridge to bracket distinct actions of reading. A third type of double exposure is created by the combination of motive A and motive B (for example, at 00:30:45 or 00:31:01, see Figure 8).

[34] In *Sherlock* (00:23:07), there is a true co-temporal double representation realized in a double exposure. Sherlock stands on the roof of a building and seeks for an escape. The image shows his emotional state: His face and the background kind of split in two, caused by two overlaid images taken from two points a few inches next to each other, like the two distinct images of the left and right eye.

[35] To be more precise, Eve is perceiving the text through her fingertips, eyes wide open as if seeing with a kind of 'inner eye'.

Figure 8. Motive A and motive B in a motion image superimposition (00:31:01)

Both examples (Figure 7.2 and Figure 8) invoke the pattern of pairing a shot of a cognitive process visible on a face (reading, looking) with a shot of the object of intention, connected via gaze and eyeline match. In their simultaneous presentation, this bond is even stronger. Instances of this pattern are for example the connection of viewer and object viewed (*Only Lovers Left Alive*), actor and object manipulated (typewriter and typist in *Man with a Movie Camera*, SU 1929 at 01:01:59, see Figure 9.1), a person talking and the content of their talk (a news reporter and the events reported in *Sherlock,* 00:04:14[36]) and generally, a protagonist visibly feeling, thinking or dreaming, and images of the things thought or felt, as for example in *Sherlock*. The image superimposition in Figure 9.2 from *Sherlock* is preceded by the same big close-up of Sherlocks face but with open eyes, while he watches CCTV footage of the London Underground. When he closes his eyes, a rapid succession of superimposed motion images starts as if to show Sherlocks thoughts, and one of these images is a train standing at a station with its doors opening (*Sherlock*, 00:45:56).



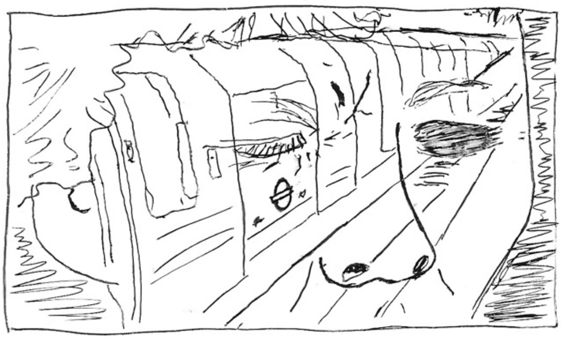


Figure 9.1 and 9.2. Woman and typewriter; Sherlock recalling CCTV footage

In *Pillow Talk* (USA 1959), there is a sequence of double exposures that reminds of the DGS example in Figure 4.1. The enamored protagonists spend a day and a night in New York and walk around, pointing out this and that. Different views from New York's scenery are superimposed onto the walking couple, e.g. the Statue of Liberty (*Pillow Talk*, 00:49:19) or a street view from high angle (*Pillow Talk*, 00:49:03). The image superimpositions here show at the same time both the sights as well as the persons with their emotional reactions visible on their faces. But while these situations could alternatively also be shown within single motion images, e.g. two persons close up and the objects of interest further away but seemingly close by way of a wide-angle lens, the arrangement of superimpositions serves another purpose and

[36] First the news reporter is seen in a medium long shot in front of an outside staircase, next to a camera man; then the scene closes in on the face of the reporter, now at the right side of the screen, while a second motion image of a police man and a person standing near the lieu of crime and subsequently other illustrations of the content reported blend in.

in this case conveys a more general atmosphere of "being in New York" and "shared leisure time".

There is a difference to be noticed. A superimposition connecting a viewer with the object seen presupposes if not a spatial but a temporal co-presence (contemporaneity) of viewer and object (otherwise the viewing would qualify as a kind of dream or vision), whereas the connection of a person thinking, dreaming or talking about something does not imply the contemporaneity of the events as presented by simultaneously projected motion images. Generally speaking, superimpositions by way of multiple exposures are free to combine same or different place and same or different time.

In *The Artist*, there is another main pattern of multiple exposures. Different recurring activities of an entire process as the production of a film are initially shown step by step in some single images, only to become more and more blended, thus compressing the time into a felt simultaneity (e.g. *The Artist*, 00:39:32). Different actions are visibly grouped, thus creating and exemplifying a joint topic. The device of connecting distinct images by laying one semitransparent image upon the other is far from being outdated, as Bazin thought. In his essay originally published in 1956, Morin (2005) observes a growing abstraction in the use of cinematic devices, similar to the process of grammaticalization in languages, and his description fits the above-mentioned examples. What is important is that all levels of meaning are always available.

> In the same way, superimposition, a magical effect at the outset (ghosts, doubling) becomes symbolico-affective (memory, dream), then purely indicative. The superimposition of a newspaper seller on the streets of New York tells us that the press is spreading throughout the city the news of the event presented in the preceding images. (Morin 2005: 173)

However, there is another type of superimposition that has not yet been acclaimed as such. Through the use of mirrors or semitransparent, reflecting window panes simultaneous motion image relations can be generated that fit the definition given in chapter 2. Window panes and mirrors provide naturally occurring superimpositions and do not have the flavor of technical production or a 'trick'.

Window panes show the graphic effects of superimposition but retain the illusion of being a natural take. They allow a view into two directions and make visible what lies behind the window, but also what lies behind the camera eye. A look through a glass often has a symbolic meaning in motion pictures, symbolizing closeness and inaccessibility at the same time. It may also serve to create an atmosphere, as in *Jongens* (NL 2014, at 00:37:06-36), where two lovers kiss inside a glass kiosk (shot from the outside), regardless of all the activity and restlessness of passers-by seen in the window pane reflection, or of customers inside the kiosk. In the same film, reflections on a large pane allow for a 360-degree view onto a scene and a dense information packaging (*Jongens* 01:07:18). A long shot shows at one glance a stadium where a race competition takes place, including a commentator behind the window of a box, the audience directly visible and the running track in the reflection (see Figure 10), which, if occurring in a single motion image, compares to a very long shot.

Figure 10. Atmosphere at the stadium with commentator, seated public and running track

A semitransparent pane can substitute a sequence of shot plus reverse shot and is even more 'reliable': Looker and object looked at belong to the same space and time, they are only separated through a pane, but not a cut. Mirrors have the same effect of granting a spatiotemporal correlation of superimposed images, but they are more similar to picture-in-picture devices.[37] Mirror scenes often feature a double representation where a character is visible from two angles of view – in front of and 'inside' the mirror. Mirrors are typically used in encounters say of two persons sitting or standing opposite to each other. A constellation like this can be framed by an over-the-shoulder shot, which presents the spatial information and bodily behavior of both characters, but the facial expressions of only one. With use of a mirror, the faces of both persons and their actions and reactions become simultaneously visible and recognizable.

6. Intermedial comparison

Superimpositions are ubiquitous in signed language discourse when highly iconic structures are employed. Looking back to chapter 2, we can recognize superimpositions even in Figures 1.2 and 1.3 (not annotated). While the hands depict the motion of the legs, the signer enacts the moving man with upper body and face as well and shows his intentions and feelings. In Figure 2, CAs of the protagonist are almost continually at play, and while the hands are partitioned off to depict cars, there are two simultaneous motion images, in other words: a motion image superimposition. All signed examples in this paper are combinations of a CA akin to a medium close-up or a real-size depiction, and a DC or re-iconized lexeme that are a model-sized depiction of a longer shot size. This kind of 'mismatch' is a first but not sufficient indication of a superimposition. Complementary representations may be identified by the established glance relation between CA and DC. Relations between depicted entities of diverse architectural spaces are preserved in representational space regardless of size scales. Double representations may not be recognized as easily, because neither a CA or a DC shows individual features of a person as for example clothes or figure to help identify characters. Identity of characters is indicated by the syntax and context, but also by a closeness of the person DC to the signer's body expressing a CA, often even close to the face (Figure 5.2), and by a similar orientation and parallel movement of DC and CA (Figure 3.3 and 3.4; Figure 1.2 and 1.3). Double representations help clarify spatial relations of a person involved in a scene and at the same time show their emotional or cognitive response.

Filmed motion image superimpositions divide into two groups, double exposures and naturally occurring reflections in mirrors and window panes. Double exposures exhibit the

[37] This becomes apparent in the popular motive of the mirror-self deviating from the actions of their real-world counterpart and taking on a life on their own, as for example in *Mary Poppins* (USA 1964) during the song "A spoonful of sugar", where the mirror-self falls in and continues singing while Mary Poppins herself has already finished.

process of laying one motion image onto another, especially if one blends into the other and causes a kind of blur. The same impression of a blur of the image is an effect of the use of reflecting window panes that give sight into two directions. With mirrors, there are no competing image elements. While double exposures are outstanding and a device of film style, mirror and window pane reflections may go unnoticed and are known from real-world experience. But in film, they are used skillfully as a device for information structuring and condensation, or for creating an atmosphere.

Whereas double or multiple exposures can combine any motion image of any time and place,[38] the use of semitransparent panes and of mirrors confines the possibility of combining arbitrary images to the conditions of spatiotemporal unity. In that respect, superimpositions effected by window panes are close to the signed superimpositions discussed, which also only combine views from the same time and the same or contiguous space. This restriction on part of the signing seems to be a grammatical constraint, at least a default, and helps to understand complex situations.

Superimpositions in sign languages and in film differ in their appearance and reveal the specific properties of sign language as well as of film, yet there are similarities with respect to structure and functions that may be due to the cognitive principles which underly our understanding of simultaneously shown images. The logic of interpreting superimpositions is based on common structural elements. Film and sign language discourse make use of the graphic spatial dimension in order to organize the expressive means of motion images relating to other motion images. Graphic relations play an important role of coherence regarding form and content also in sequences (cf. Bordwell et al. 2019: 219-224 on editing principles in film; Müller 2018: 313 and 315 with two illustrated examples from DGS), but superimpositions seem to enforce this kind of relationship. They are the result of a simultaneous mapping of two distinct architectural spaces onto one representational space[39], adding a surplus structure of graphic relations between elements of both input spaces. They make intentional, spatial and temporal relations visible through that mapping. Relevant features are closeness or congruence in representational space, orientation or movement toward or away from a point in representational space, and the construction of patterns. In this respect, superimposition is an iconic device exploiting emerging spatial relations.

A main function of signed and filmed image superimpositions is the direct visibility and connectedness of intentional, spatial or temporal relations between a protagonist and a situation. For example, the gaze of a character is directly linked from one architectural space to the other or the object seen is literally in the eyes of the beholder. In sign languages, superimpositions are a convenient device to depict a broader situation and focus on a character within this situation, that is, to show overview and detail at the same time. This is done by the combination of CA and depicting signs, analogous to a medium close-up shot with a long or medium shot. In film superimpositions, the function of showing intentional relations (cognitive processes) between a character and the intentional objects prevails, especially in double exposures. This also extends to the illustration of talk or thoughts.[40] Another shared structure between film and signed discourse is the embedding of superimpositions into sequences in which the constituents are contextually introduced in some way or another, thus preparing a viewer or addressee for the complexity of the combination.

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[38] See for example Galt (2005: 11) on a movie by Lars von Trier, who used superimpositions of images that “preclude the production of a single, stable diegesis”.

[39] At the extreme, these architectural spaces may be identical except for one mobile element, which covers different locations at different times (see motive C from *Only Lovers Left Alive*).

[40] Such a combination could also be found in sign language discourse in a sequence of constructed dialogue where the signer embodies a character (motion image one), while depicting constructions occurring as parts of the shown or ‘quoted’ utterance would qualify as motion image two, possibly showing a situation disconnected to the time and place of the shown utterance.

7 Conclusion

Film narrations and signed discourse differ much with respect to their kinds and uses of iconicity. Photorealistic pictures in film address the eye and the ear close to a real-world experience including the perception of movement and the passing of time, while in signed languages iconic features of DC are more abstract. They rather resemble "schematic visual representations" (Kogill-Coez 2000) than elaborate, detailed pictorial representations. CA constructions though, when the hands are used to represent human hands in action along with corresponding face expression and upper body movement, manifest a kind of iconicity similar to a real-world experience (of a human behaving such and such), and this is true especially for facial expressions differentiating a broad range of emotions with all possible nuances, which can be attributed to any animate being in a narrative.

The kinds of iconicity in film and signed language are different, but both media have motion images of their own kind, that are combined sequentially or at times simultaneously. It is remarkable both for film and signed languages how frequent combinations of a scene depiction and the emotional or cognitive response of a facial expression are. Prince (1993: 24) points out the importance of the face and its expressions as another level of iconic information in film, which is "central to a consideration of the comprehensibility and emotional effects of the cinema," and he underlines

> film's ability to capture the subtleties and nuances of socially resonant streams of kinesic expressions, and not just to passively capture them but, via close-ups and other expressive devices, to intensify and emphasize the most salient cues for the viewer's understanding in cognitive and affective terms of the meaning of the scenes depicted on screen. (Prince 1993: 24)

Considering the initial question of the kind of iconicity that seems to be at stake with motion image superimpositions, what could be more iconic than seeing this connection of "kinesic expressions" and "scenes depicted on screen" not in succession but simultaneously? Superimpositions are backed up by the inherent iconicity of the face and its visible connections to the respective situations of outer or inner world. This is true also for signed superimpositions, where the facial expressions play such a crucial role.

To summarize the findings of this paper, the general meaning of image superimpositions or the interpretation strategy that we can derive from the sign language and film examples may be stated as follows: situation A and situation B (and possibly more), or aspect A and aspect B of a situation (and possibly more) are considered *one* on a higher level. This unity is visible on the representational space, and interrelations of pictorial elements of all input motion images may be interpreted according to their respective positions, movements and interactions.

This view accounts for the complex situation of a protagonist and their surroundings (all signed examples, examples from *Pillow Talk, Jongens* and Figure 8 from *Only Lovers Left Alive*), or for the combination of a protagonist's mind and the ‚content' of this mind, i.e. what is handled, looked at, dreamt or talked about (looking at the traffic, skyscrapers or a river in Figures 2.3, 4.1 and 5.2 or handling a typewriter (Figure 9.1) or a book (Figures 7.2 and 8), reminiscing CCTV footage (Figure 9.2) or reporting the daily news as in *Sherlock*), or the complex simultaneous arrangement of separate activities belonging to one process, as the direction and production of a movie film in *The Artist*.

Double or multiple exposures provide film directors with a means of ultimate combinatorial freedom. Still the interpretive strategy applies: even if there is no prima-facie relation between two simultaneously presented motion images in film, as in the example from

Galt (2005), the viewer will expect and eventually find one. Superimposition, as Morin (2005:173) put it, is also a mere grammatical function of indication – and, it should be added, connectivity. And this is true also for all those examples where meaning construction is intended and easily performed.

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